

When Anxiety Feels Like Love

For some people, anxiety and love have become entangled — worrying about others as a form of caring, anxious attachment as the shape love takes.

ANXIETY WORKSHEET LIBRARY — STAGE PROGRESS

ANXIETY IN RELATIONSHIP

If you grew up in an environment where love and worry were intertwined — where caring meant monitoring, where closeness came with fear of loss — your nervous system may have learned to express love through anxiety. This worksheet is for people who recognise that pattern.

1 Anxiety About the People You Love

List the people you worry about most. For each, describe what you worry about and how much of your mental space they occupy.

PERSON	WHAT YOU WORRY ABOUT REGARDING THEM	HOURS/WEEK THINKING ABOUT THEM	WHAT WORRYING DOES FOR YOU

2 Where This Pattern Came From

Anxiety as care often has a relational history. Was worry modelled for you as a child? Was love communicated through anxiety? Was being needed how you earned connection?

3 Untangling Anxiety from Love

Worrying about someone is not the same as loving them. Often it serves the worrier more than the person being worried about. What would it look like to love the people you care about without the worry? What would you do differently?

4 What You Need in Relationships

Anxious attachment often reflects unmet needs for security, closeness, or reassurance. What do you actually need in your closest relationships — that you haven't been able to ask for directly?

CLOSING REFLECTION

What would it feel like to love someone without needing to monitor their safety to know you still love them?

BETWEEN-SESSION PRACTICE

Notice once this week when you're worrying about someone you love. Ask: *"Is this worry doing something for me — or something for them?"* Write one honest sentence about what you find. There's no judgment in the answer.

BRING TO YOUR SESSION

- Where do you recognise the pattern of anxiety and love being entangled?
- What does worrying give you that you couldn't get another way?
- What do you most need in your closest relationships — and how could you ask for it more directly?